China, forming a powerful countermeasure and deterrent capability against foreigners who would artificially cut off supply [to China]'.[12]

This is weaponization of interdependence, and explicit adoption of punitive commercial measures when necessary. China condemns the use of trade for political ends. However, it reserves the right to resort to the same tactics, either in retaliation for trade measures adopted against its trade practices, or quite often for political reasons. When Australia called for an independent investigation into the origins of the coronavirus, which first appeared in the Chinese city of Wuhan, China retaliated by putting high tariffs on imports of Australian wine and barley. This despite the two countries having a free trade agreement.

This inward turn in economic policies has also been accompanied by what Xi has called Pursuit of Common Prosperity. The phrase denotes a more egalitarian distribution of wealth, in contrast to Deng Xiaoping's policy of allowing some individuals and localities to get rich first. The forty years of rapid growth raised the country's GDP and its per capita income, eliminating 'severe poverty', but it also created huge inequalities of wealth and income. Chinese reports point out that the Gini coefficient, which measures income and wealth inequality, rose from 0.32 in the early years of reform to 0.46 in 2019 (the closer the coefficient is to 1 the greater the inequality). In May 2020, Premier Li Keqiang said that China still had 600 million people, or over 40 per cent of its population, whose monthly income was barely US$140. Since taking office as China's top leader, Xi Jinping has signalled his worry about the ostentatious display of wealth and the rising influence of China's successful multinational companies, especially those in the high-tech and digital space. He has linked this to pervasive corruption, which has had a corrosive impact on both Party and society. Common Prosperity is aimed at reducing glaring inequalities of wealth and income by achieving an income distribution which is 'olive shaped', meaning a large middle class with smaller ends at the bottom and top of the economic ladder. Xi regards a more equitable distribution as being important for ensuring political and social stability – which is why he has described Common Prosperity as a 'focal point' for 'ensuring the long-term